Nikolai Bukharin and Yevgeni Preobrazhensky (a paperback copy soon joined his prized possessions).

Away from the classroom, students were obliged to work once a week in a labour brigade and Honecker proved sharp enough to be allotted to a team as a welder in the Elektrozavod electro works, handling an oxy-acetylene welding torch. There were carefree moments at the cinema and theatre, he developed a lasting interest in the performing arts and discovered a love of beer, a taste which stayed with him, though rarely indulged. With a stubby Zenit cigarette welded to his lips, he cut a dashing figure, standing at 1.68m, with a mop of ash blonde hair and appealing facial features. A robust 18-year-old in 1930, he felt the normal stirrings of any red-blooded teen and broke several maidens' hearts. Most memorably, he embarked on a passionate liaison with Natasha Griyenda, an auburn-haired Elektrozavod employee who he met at a dance. 'This relationship ended because I only stayed in Moscow for a year. It was hard,' he later confided. In fact, by dating Griyenda, he breached the strict rules of the Lenin school which forbade students from fraternising with strangers. Natasha's photograph travelled in his wallet long after, but they would never meet again.

As well as working at Elektrozavod, the young communist was active in Osoaviakhim, a volunteer organisation tasked with instilling militarist values into the population by providing civil defence and helping modernise the country. 'I received good military training in accordance with the teaching programme and was particularly attracted to equestrian sport,' he said. 'Sometimes it happened that I was late for classes because of the cavalry training … but just imagine what it meant to be a cavalryman in those days!'2

He scrutinised his Soviet surroundings and his new Russian friends with care, spotting, for example, the huge education drive in Moscow, where citizens learnt to read, write and do arithmetic. 'Young and old were seen on the street, reading and learning at every opportunity.' Since his arrival coincided with the first preparations for the brand-new metro, the first underground railway system in the Soviet Union, it is a fair guess that he inspected the early earthworks, overseen by a young Nikita Khrushchev. Whatever his views really were, Honecker's memoirs skip over the